

Describing Meaning – Week 10

Aktionsart (Aspectual Classes)

1. Recap: Aspectual classes

This week we use three basic features to classify eventualities:

- [**±static**]: is the situation dynamic or not?
- [**±durative**]: does it extend over an interval, or is it (near-)instantaneous?
- [**±telic**]: does it have an inherent endpoint / culmination?

We then divide eventualities into four main classes:

- **States** [**+static, +durative, –telic**]
Obtain rather than occur. Homogeneous, have the subinterval property, usually non-volitional.
Examples: know, believe, have, love, be proud, fear.
- **Activities** [**–static, +durative, –telic**]
Dynamic, take time, do not culminate; limited subinterval property, typically volitional.
Examples: run, walk, talk, sing, drive a car, watch birds.
- **Accomplishments** [**–static, +durative, +telic**]
Dynamic, take time and culminate; no subinterval property; usually volitional, with preparation–culmination–result structure.
Examples: paint a picture, build a house, write an essay.
- **Achievements** [**–static, –durative, +telic**]
Culminate but are (more or less) instantaneous; no subinterval property; usually non-volitional, with event–result structure.
Examples: recognize, spot, find, lose, die, notice.

1.1 Feature table

Situations	Static	Durative	Telic
State	+	+	–
Activity	–	+	–
Accomplishment	–	+	+
Achievement	–	–	+

2. Tests for Aktionsart

2.1 Telicity and *for/in* adverbials

For each pair, judge which sentences are acceptable in the intended reading. Use your judgments to formulate a generalization about which aspectual classes combine with *for*-adverbials and which with *in*-adverbials.

- (1) a. Carla ran for fifteen minutes.
b. Carla ran in fifteen minutes.
- (2) a. Carla arrived for fifteen minutes.
b. Carla arrived in fifteen minutes.
- (3) a. Carla did her homework for fifteen minutes.
b. Carla did her homework in fifteen minutes.
- (4) a. Carla was happy for fifteen minutes.
b. Carla was happy in fifteen minutes.

2.2 Habitual readings in the simple present

For each sentence below, decide whether the simple present has a **habitual** reading, a **non-habitual** (single eventuality) reading, or both. Use your answers to form a generalization: for which aspectual classes does the simple present naturally yield a habitual reading?

- (5) Arnold recognises the car.
- (6) Arnold crosses the street.
- (7) Arnold fears spiders.
- (8) Arnold pets a dog.
- (9) Arnold runs.

- (10) Arnold is afraid of spiders.

2.3 The *finish* test

Judge the acceptability of each sentence with *finish*. Then propose a generalization: with which aspectual class(es) can *finish* combine?

- (11) Arnold finished recognising the car.
(12) Arnold finished crossing the street.
(13) Arnold finished being afraid of spiders.
(14) Arnold finished writing the essay.
(15) Arnold finished petting a dog.

2.4 Agentive adverbs: *carefully* / *deliberately*

Judge the acceptability of the following. Then: which aspectual class(es) can be modified by agentive adverbs like *carefully* and *deliberately*?

- (16) Arnold carefully/deliberately recognised the car.
(17) Arnold carefully/deliberately crossed the street.
(18) Arnold carefully/deliberately was afraid of spiders.
(19) Arnold carefully/deliberately petted a dog.

2.5 Speed adverbs: *quickly* / *slowly*

Judge the acceptability of the following and formulate a generalization: which aspectual class(es) can be modified by *quickly* and *slowly*? Are there different readings (event-internal vs. onset)?

- (20) Arnold quickly/slowly recognised the car.
(21) Arnold quickly/slowly crossed the street.
(22) Arnold quickly/slowly was afraid of spiders.
(23) Arnold quickly/slowly knew the time.
(24) Arnold quickly/slowly wrote the essay.

- (25) Arnold quickly/slowly petted a dog.

2.6 *When*-adverbials

Consider sentences of the form:

A will happen when B happens.

For some B-clauses, *when* tends to mean *more or less at the same time as B*; for others it tends to mean *at some point during the period when B holds*.

For each sentence, decide which reading is more natural and then connect this to the aspectual class of the predicate in the *when*-clause.

- (26) Arnold will jump three times when he reaches the top of the mountain.
(27) Arnold will jump three times when he crosses the street.
(28) Arnold will jump three times when he is afraid of spiders.
(29) Arnold will jump three times when he knows the time.
(30) Arnold will jump three times when he runs.
(31) Arnold will jump three times when he runs a mile.

3. Back to *is released* and the Preap case

Consider again the (abridged) statute discussed in class:

The Attorney General shall take into custody any alien who meets any of the criteria (a)–(d) when the alien is released.

- (a) Using our diagnostics, argue for a classification of the predicate *is released* in the legally relevant reading (passive vs. adjectival). Is it best treated as a state, activity, accomplishment, or achievement?
(b) Explain how that classification predicts whether *when the alien is released* should favour a “roughly at the same time” reading or an “at any time during the state” reading.
(c) Briefly say how this bears on the interpretation of the statute in the Preap case.